



So near yet so far: A late blunder by defending champion Ding Liren enabled Gukesh to secure a dramatic last-gasp victory. FIDE/ENG CHIN AN

blow — with black pieces. Gukesh was punished for overreach; he tried to play too aggressively when the position didn't demand it, and after a capture with a wrong piece in the middle game, things became difficult for him. Ding consolidated his advantage and went on to win the first game. He did not just win the game but made a statement and answered some questions about his form and his mental shape (he had gone on record about seeking professional help).

He was also answering his critics, all those top players who had said he stood little chance against a challenger who had been in top form for the last couple of years. The defeat must have been a setback for Gukesh.

But shortly after the match was

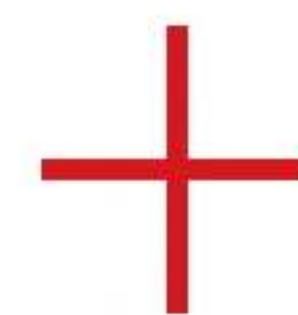
over, when *Sportstar* caught up with Gajewski and Upton, they both said that they were glad that the defeat came at the very start. "That quickly awakened him from his dream," the coach said. **The mental coach said Gukesh was prepared for a bad game, and a strategy had been put in place to deal with it.**

Whatever that strategy was, it worked.

After the second game was drawn, Gukesh won the third. It was a game that showed why Gukesh could be such a dangerous

opponent for even the strongest of players. He could play one best possible move — even according to the strongest chess engine — after one best possible move.

Daniil Dubov, the Russian Grandmaster who was the second of Magnus Carlsen twice for the World championship, had told this writer recently that when Gukesh was at his best, he was like an engine: you may not be able to find out immediately why he made a certain move; it may not make sense at the time, but later you will realise why, after the



D. Gukesh had Viswanathan Anand as his mentor, a living legend with the experience of playing the World championship matches for two decades and being the champion five times.